

Diabetes

Diabetes is a common condition that affects people of all ages. There are several forms of diabetes. Type 2 is the most common. A combination of treatment strategies can help you manage the condition to live a healthy life and prevent complications.

What is diabetes?

Diabetes is a condition that happens when your blood sugar (glucose) is too high. It develops when your [pancreas](#) doesn't make enough [insulin](#) or any at all, or when your body isn't responding to the effects of insulin properly. Diabetes affects people of all ages. Most forms of diabetes are chronic (lifelong), and all forms are manageable with medications and/or lifestyle changes.

Glucose (sugar) mainly comes from [carbohydrates](#) in your food and drinks. It's your body's go-to source of energy. Your blood carries glucose to all your body's cells to use for energy.

When glucose is in your bloodstream, it needs help — a “key” — to reach its final destination. This key is insulin (a [hormone](#)). If your pancreas isn't making enough insulin or your body isn't using it properly, glucose builds up in your bloodstream, causing [high blood sugar \(hyperglycemia\)](#).

Over time, having consistently high blood glucose can cause health problems, such as [heart disease](#), nerve damage and eye issues.

The technical name for diabetes is diabetes mellitus. Another condition shares the term “diabetes” — [diabetes insipidus](#) — but they're distinct. They share the name “diabetes” because they both cause increased thirst and frequent urination. Diabetes insipidus is much rarer than diabetes mellitus.

What are the types of diabetes?

There are several types of diabetes. The most common forms include:

- **[Type 2 diabetes](#)**: With this type, your body doesn't make enough insulin and/or your body's cells don't respond normally to the insulin ([insulin resistance](#)). This is the most common type of diabetes. It mainly affects adults, but children can have it as well.
- **[Prediabetes](#)**: This type is the stage before Type 2 diabetes. Your blood glucose levels are higher than normal but not high enough to be officially diagnosed with Type 2 diabetes.
- **[Type 1 diabetes](#)**: This type is an [autoimmune disease](#) in which your [immune system](#) attacks and destroys insulin-producing cells in your pancreas for unknown reasons. Up to 10% of people who have diabetes have Type 1. It's usually diagnosed in [children](#) and young adults, but it can develop at any age.

- **[Gestational diabetes](#)**: This type develops in some people during [pregnancy](#). Gestational diabetes usually goes away after pregnancy. However, if you have gestational diabetes, you're at a higher risk of developing Type 2 diabetes later in life.

Other types of diabetes include:

- **[Type 3c diabetes](#)**: This form of diabetes happens when your pancreas experiences damage (other than autoimmune damage), which affects its ability to produce insulin. [Pancreatitis](#), [pancreatic cancer](#), [cystic fibrosis](#) and [hemochromatosis](#) can all lead to pancreas damage that causes diabetes. Having your pancreas removed ([pancreatectomy](#)) also results in Type 3c.
- **[Latent autoimmune diabetes in adults \(LADA\)](#)**: Like Type 1 diabetes, LADA also results from an autoimmune reaction, but it develops much more slowly than Type 1. People diagnosed with LADA are usually over the age of 30.
- **[Maturity-onset diabetes of the young \(MODY\)](#)**: MODY, also called monogenic diabetes, happens due to an inherited [genetic mutation](#) that affects how your body makes and uses insulin. There are currently over 10 different types of MODY. It affects up to 5% of people with diabetes and commonly runs in families.
- **Neonatal diabetes**: This is a rare form of diabetes that occurs within the first six months of life. It's also a form of monogenic diabetes. About 50% of babies with neonatal diabetes have the lifelong form called permanent neonatal diabetes mellitus. For the other half, the condition disappears within a few months from onset, but it can come back later in life. This is called transient neonatal diabetes mellitus.
- **[Brittle diabetes](#)**: Brittle diabetes is a form of Type 1 diabetes that's marked by frequent and severe episodes of high and low blood sugar levels. This instability often leads to hospitalization. In rare cases, a [pancreas transplant](#) may be necessary to permanently treat brittle diabetes.

- **How common is diabetes?**
- Diabetes is common. Approximately 37.3 million people in the United States have diabetes, which is about 11% of the population. Type 2 diabetes is the most common form, representing 90% to 95% of all diabetes cases.
- About 537 million adults across the world have diabetes. Experts predict this number will rise to 643 million by 2030 and 783 million by 2045.

Symptoms and Causes

What are the symptoms of diabetes?

Symptoms of diabetes include:

- Increased thirst ([polydipsia](#)) and [dry mouth](#).

- [Frequent urination](#).
- Fatigue.
- [Blurred vision](#).
- [Unexplained weight loss](#).
- [Numbness](#) or tingling in your hands or feet.
- Slow-healing sores or cuts.
- Frequent skin and/or [vaginal yeast infections](#).

It's important to talk to your healthcare provider if you or your child has these symptoms.

Additional details about symptoms per type of diabetes include:

- **Type 1 diabetes:** Symptoms of T1D can develop quickly — over a few weeks or months. You may develop additional symptoms that are signs of a severe complication called [diabetes-related ketoacidosis \(DKA\)](#). **DKA is life-threatening and requires immediate medical treatment.** DKA symptoms include [vomiting](#), stomach pains, fruity-smelling breath and labored breathing.
- **Type 2 diabetes and prediabetes:** You may not have any symptoms at all, or you may not notice them since they develop slowly. Routine bloodwork may show a high blood sugar level before you recognize symptoms. Another possible sign of prediabetes is darkened skin on certain parts of your body ([acanthosis nigricans](#)).
- **Gestational diabetes:** You typically won't notice symptoms of gestational diabetes. Your healthcare provider will test you for gestational diabetes between 24 and 28 weeks of pregnancy.

What causes diabetes?

Too much glucose circulating in your bloodstream causes diabetes, regardless of the type. However, the reason why your blood glucose levels are high differs depending on the type of diabetes.

Causes of diabetes include:

- **Insulin resistance:** Type 2 diabetes mainly results from insulin resistance. Insulin resistance happens when cells in your [muscles](#), fat and [liver](#) don't respond as they should to insulin. Several factors and conditions contribute to varying degrees of insulin resistance, including obesity, lack of physical activity, diet, hormonal imbalances, genetics and certain medications.
- **Autoimmune disease:** Type 1 diabetes and LADA happen when your immune system attacks the insulin-producing cells in your pancreas.

- **[Hormonal imbalances](#)**: During pregnancy, the [placenta](#) releases hormones that cause insulin resistance. You may develop gestational diabetes if your pancreas can't produce enough insulin to overcome the insulin resistance. Other hormone-related conditions like [acromegaly](#) and [Cushing syndrome](#) can also cause Type 2 diabetes.
- **Pancreatic damage**: Physical damage to your pancreas — from a condition, surgery or injury — can impact its ability to make insulin, resulting in Type 3c diabetes.
- **Genetic mutations**: Certain genetic mutations can cause MODY and neonatal diabetes.

Long-term use of certain medications can also lead to Type 2 diabetes, including [HIV/AIDS](#) medications and [corticosteroids](#).

What are the complications of diabetes?

Diabetes can lead to acute (sudden and severe) and long-term complications — mainly due to extreme or prolonged high blood sugar levels.

Acute diabetes complications

Acute diabetes complications that can be life-threatening include:

- **[Hyperosmolar hyperglycemic state \(HHS\)](#)**: This complication mainly affects people with Type 2 diabetes. It happens when your blood sugar levels are very high (over 600 milligrams per deciliter or mg/dL) for a long period, leading to severe [dehydration](#) and confusion. It requires immediate medical treatment.
- **Diabetes-related ketoacidosis (DKA)**: This complication mainly affects people with Type 1 diabetes or undiagnosed T1D. It happens when your body doesn't have enough insulin. If your body doesn't have insulin, it can't use glucose for energy, so it breaks down fat instead. This process eventually releases substances called ketones, which turn your blood acidic. This causes labored breathing, vomiting and loss of consciousness. DKA requires immediate medical treatment.
- **Severe [low blood sugar \(hypoglycemia\)](#)**: Hypoglycemia happens when your blood sugar level drops below the range that's healthy for you. Severe hypoglycemia is very low blood sugar. It mainly affects people with diabetes who use insulin. Signs include blurred or double vision, clumsiness, disorientation and seizures. It requires treatment with [emergency glucagon](#) and/or medical intervention.

Long-term diabetes complications

Blood glucose levels that remain high for too long can damage your body's tissues and organs. This is mainly due to damage to your blood vessels and nerves, which support your body's tissues.

Cardiovascular (heart and blood vessel) issues are the most common type of long-term diabetes complication. They include:

- [Coronary artery disease](#).
- [Heart attack](#).
- [Stroke](#).
- [Atherosclerosis](#).

Other diabetes complications include:

- Nerve damage ([neuropathy](#)), which can cause numbness, tingling and/or pain.
- [Nephropathy](#), which can lead to [kidney failure](#) or the need for [dialysis](#) or [transplant](#).
- [Retinopathy](#), which can lead to blindness.
- [Diabetes-related foot conditions](#).
- Skin infections.
- [Amputations](#).
- [Sexual dysfunction](#) due to nerve and blood vessel damage, such as [erectile dysfunction](#) or [vaginal dryness](#).
- [Gastroparesis](#).
- [Hearing loss](#).
- Oral health issues, such as [gum \(periodontal\) disease](#).

Living with diabetes can also affect your mental health. People with diabetes are two to three times more likely to have [depression](#) than people without diabetes.

Diagnosis and Tests

How is diabetes diagnosed?

Healthcare providers diagnose diabetes by checking your [glucose level in a blood test](#). Three tests can measure your blood glucose level:

- **Fasting blood glucose test:** For this test, you don't eat or drink anything except water (fast) for at least eight hours before the test. As food can greatly affect blood sugar, this test allows your provider to see your baseline blood sugar.
- **Random blood glucose test:** "Random" means that you can get this test at any time, regardless of if you've fasted.

- [A1c](#): This test, also called HbA1C or glycated hemoglobin test, provides your average blood glucose level over the past two to three months.

To screen for and diagnose gestational diabetes, providers order an [oral glucose tolerance test](#).

The following test results typically indicate if you don't have diabetes, have prediabetes or have diabetes. These values may vary slightly. In addition, healthcare providers rely on more than one test to diagnose diabetes.

Type of test
Fasting blood glucose test
In-range (mg/dL) Less than 100.
Prediabetes (mg/dL) 100 to 125.
Diabetes (mg/L) 126 or higher.

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Random blood glucose test
In-range (mg/dL) N/A.
Prediabetes (mg/dL) N/A.
Diabetes (mg/L) 200 or higher (with classic symptoms of hyperglycemia or hyperglycemic crisis).
A1c
In-range (mg/dL) Less than 5.7%.
Prediabetes (mg/dL) 5.7% to 6.4%.
Diabetes (mg/L) 6.5% or higher.

Management and Treatment

How is diabetes managed?

Diabetes is a complex condition, so its management involves several strategies. In addition, diabetes affects everyone differently, so management plans are highly individualized.

The four main aspects of managing diabetes include:

- **Blood sugar monitoring:** Monitoring your blood sugar (glucose) is key to determining how well your current treatment plan is working. It gives you information on how to manage your diabetes on a daily — and sometimes even hourly — basis. You can monitor your levels with frequent checks with a glucose meter and finger stick and/or with a [continuous glucose monitor](#) (CGM). You and your healthcare provider will determine the best blood sugar range for you.
- **Oral diabetes medications:** Oral diabetes medications (taken by mouth) help manage blood sugar levels in people who have diabetes but still produce some insulin — mainly people with Type 2 diabetes and prediabetes. People with gestational

diabetes may also need oral medication. There are several different types. [Metformin](#) is the most common.

- **Insulin:** People with Type 1 diabetes need to inject synthetic insulin to live and manage diabetes. Some people with Type 2 diabetes also require insulin. There are several different types of synthetic insulin. They each start to work at different speeds and last in your body for different lengths of time. The four main ways you can take insulin include [injectable insulin](#) with a syringe (shot), [insulin pens](#), [insulin pumps](#) and [rapid-acting inhaled insulin](#).
- **Diet:** Meal planning and choosing a healthy diet for you are key aspects of diabetes management, as food greatly impacts blood sugar. If you take insulin, counting carbs in the food and drinks you consume is a large part of management. The amount of carbs you eat determines how much insulin you need at meals. Healthy eating habits can also help you manage your weight and reduce your heart disease risk.
- **Exercise:** Physical activity increases insulin sensitivity (and helps reduce insulin resistance), so regular exercise is an important part of management for all people with diabetes.

Due to the increased risk for heart disease, it's also important to maintain a healthy:

- Weight.
- [Blood pressure](#).
- [Cholesterol](#).

Outlook / Prognosis

What is the prognosis for diabetes?

The prognosis (outlook) for diabetes varies greatly depending on several factors, including:

- The type of diabetes.
- How well you manage the condition over time and your access to diabetes care.
- Your age at diagnosis/how long you've had diabetes.
- If you have other health conditions.
- If you develop diabetes complications.

Chronic high blood sugar can cause severe complications, which are [usually irreversible](#). Several studies have shown that untreated chronic high blood sugar shortens your lifespan and worsens your quality of life.

In the United States, diabetes is the eighth leading cause of death. A large number of people with diabetes will die from a heart attack or stroke.

However, it's important to know that you can live a healthy life with diabetes. The following are key to a better prognosis:

- Lifestyle changes.
- Regular exercise.
- Dietary changes.
- Regular blood sugar monitoring.

Studies show that people with diabetes may be able to reduce their risk of complications by consistently keeping their A1c levels below 7%.

Prevention

How can I prevent diabetes?

You can't prevent autoimmune and genetic forms of diabetes. But there are some steps you can take to [lower your risk](#) for developing prediabetes, Type 2 diabetes and gestational diabetes, including:

- Eat a healthy diet, such as the [Mediterranean](#) diet.
- Get physically active. Aim for 30 minutes a day at least five days a week.
- Work to achieve a weight that's healthy for you.
- [Manage your stress](#).
- Limit alcohol intake.
- Get adequate [sleep](#) (typically 7 to 9 hours) and seek treatment for sleep disorders.
- [Quit smoking](#).
- Take medications as directed by your healthcare provider to manage existing risk factors for heart disease.

It's important to note that there are some diabetes risk factors you can't change, such as your genetics/family history, age and race. Know that Type 2 diabetes is a complex condition that involves many contributing factors.

Living With

When should I see my healthcare provider?

If you haven't been diagnosed with diabetes, you should see a healthcare provider if you have any symptoms of diabetes, such as increased thirst and frequent urination.

If you have diabetes, you should see your provider who helps you manage diabetes (such as an [endocrinologist](#)) regularly.

Why do you need to develop a healthy-eating plan?

If you have diabetes or prediabetes, your healthcare professional will likely recommend that you see a dietitian to help you develop a healthy-eating plan. The plan helps you manage your blood sugar, also called blood glucose, manage your weight and heart disease risk factors. These factors include high blood pressure and high cholesterol.

When you eat extra calories and carbohydrates, your blood sugar level rises. If blood sugar isn't managed, it can lead to serious issues. These issues include a high blood sugar level, called hyperglycemia. If this high level lasts for a long time, it may lead to long-term complications, such as nerve, kidney and heart damage.

You can help keep your blood sugar level in a safe range. Make healthy food choices and track your eating habits.

For most people with type 2 diabetes, weight loss also can make it easier to manage blood sugar. Weight loss offers a host of other health benefits. If you need to lose weight, a healthy-eating plan provides a well-organized, nutritious way to reach your goal safely.

What does a diet for people with diabetes involve?

A diet for people living with diabetes is based on eating healthy meals at regular times. Eating meals at regular times helps your body better use insulin that it makes or gets through medicine.

A registered dietitian can help you put together a diet based on your health goals, tastes and lifestyle. The dietitian also can talk with you about how to improve your eating habits. Options include choosing portion sizes that suit your needs for your size and activity level.

Recommended foods

Make your calories count with nutritious foods. Choose healthy carbohydrates, fiber-rich foods, fish and "good" fats.

Healthy carbohydrates

During digestion, sugars and starches break down into blood glucose. Sugars also are known as simple carbohydrates, and starches also are known as complex carbohydrates. Focus on healthy carbohydrates, such as:

- Fruits.
- Vegetables.
- Whole grains.
- Legumes, such as beans and peas.
- Low-fat dairy products, such as milk and cheese.

Avoid less healthy carbohydrates, such as foods or drinks with added fats, sugars and sodium.

Fiber-rich foods

Dietary fiber includes all parts of plant foods that your body can't digest or absorb. Fiber moderates how your body digests food and helps manage blood sugar levels. Foods high in fiber include:

- Vegetables.
- Fruits. For the most fiber benefit, eat whole fruits rather than drinking fruit juice.
- Nuts.
- Legumes, such as beans and peas.
- Whole grains.

Heart-healthy fish

Eat heart-healthy fish at least twice a week. Fish such as salmon, mackerel, tuna and sardines are rich in omega-3 fatty acids. These omega-3s may prevent heart disease. Avoid fried fish.

If you are pregnant, are planning to get pregnant or are breastfeeding, do not eat fish that's typically high in mercury. This includes shark, swordfish, king mackerel and tilefish.

'Good' fats

Foods containing monounsaturated and polyunsaturated fats can help lower your cholesterol levels. These include:

- Avocados.
- Nuts.
- Canola, olive and peanut oils.

But don't overdo it, as all fats are high in calories.

Foods to avoid

Diabetes raises your risk of heart disease and stroke by raising the rate at which you develop clogged and hardened arteries. Foods containing the following can work against your goal of a heart-healthy diet.

- **Saturated fats.** Avoid high-fat dairy products and animal proteins such as butter, beef, hot dogs, sausage and bacon. Limit coconut and palm kernel oils.

- **Trans fats.** Avoid trans fats found in processed snacks, baked goods, shortening and stick margarines.
- **Cholesterol.** Cholesterol sources include high-fat dairy products and high-fat animal proteins, egg yolks, liver, and other organ meats. Aim to keep dietary cholesterol as low as possible through healthy eating, rather than aiming for a specific milligram limit.
- **Sodium.** Aim for no more than 2,300 milligrams (mg) of sodium a day. Your healthcare professional may suggest you aim for a smaller amount if you have high blood pressure.

Putting it all together: Creating a plan

You may use a few different approaches to create a healthy diet to help you keep your blood sugar level within a typical range. With a dietitian's help, you may find that one or a combination of the following methods works for you.

The plate method

The American Diabetes Association offers a simple method of meal planning. It focuses on eating more vegetables. Follow these steps when preparing your plate:

- Fill half of your plate with nonstarchy vegetables, such as spinach, carrots and tomatoes.
- Fill a quarter of your plate with a lean protein, such as fish, lean pork or chicken.
- Fill the last quarter with a carbohydrate, such as brown rice or a starchy vegetable, such as green peas.
- Include "good" fats such as nuts or avocados in small amounts.
- Add a piece of fruit or a serving of dairy and a drink of water or unsweetened tea or coffee.

Counting carbohydrates

Because carbohydrates break down into sugar, they have the greatest effect on your blood sugar level. To help manage your blood sugar, you may need to learn to figure out the amount of carbohydrates you are eating with the help of a dietitian. You can then adjust the dose of insulin accordingly. It's important to keep track of the amount of carbohydrates in each meal or snack.

A dietitian can teach you how to measure food portions and become an educated reader of food labels. You also can learn how to pay special attention to serving size and carbohydrate content.

Choose your foods

A dietitian may recommend you choose specific foods to help plan meals and snacks. You can choose a number of foods from lists that include categories such as carbohydrates, proteins and fats.

One serving in a category is called a choice. Each food choice has about the same amount of carbohydrates, protein, fat and calories — and the same effect on your blood sugar — as a serving of every other food in that same category. For example, carbohydrate lists that include starch, fruits and milk have choices that are each 15 grams of carbohydrates.

Glycemic index

Some people who live with diabetes use the glycemic index to select foods, especially carbohydrates. This method ranks food that contains carbohydrates based on their effect on blood sugar levels. Talk with your dietitian about whether this method might work for you.

What are the results of this kind of diet?

Embracing a healthy-eating plan is the best way to keep your blood sugar level under control and prevent diabetes complications. And if you need to lose weight, you can tailor the plan to your specific goals.

Aside from managing your diabetes, a healthy-eating plan offers other benefits too. Because this plan recommends generous amounts of fruits, vegetables and fiber, following it is likely to lower your risk of cardiovascular diseases and certain types of cancer. And eating dairy products and other foods rich in calcium can help keep bones healthy and strong.

Are there any risks?

If you live with diabetes, it's important that you partner with your healthcare professional and dietitian to create an eating plan that works for you. Use healthy foods, portion control and a schedule to manage your blood sugar level. If you don't follow your prescribed diet, you run the risk of blood sugar levels that change often and more-serious complications.